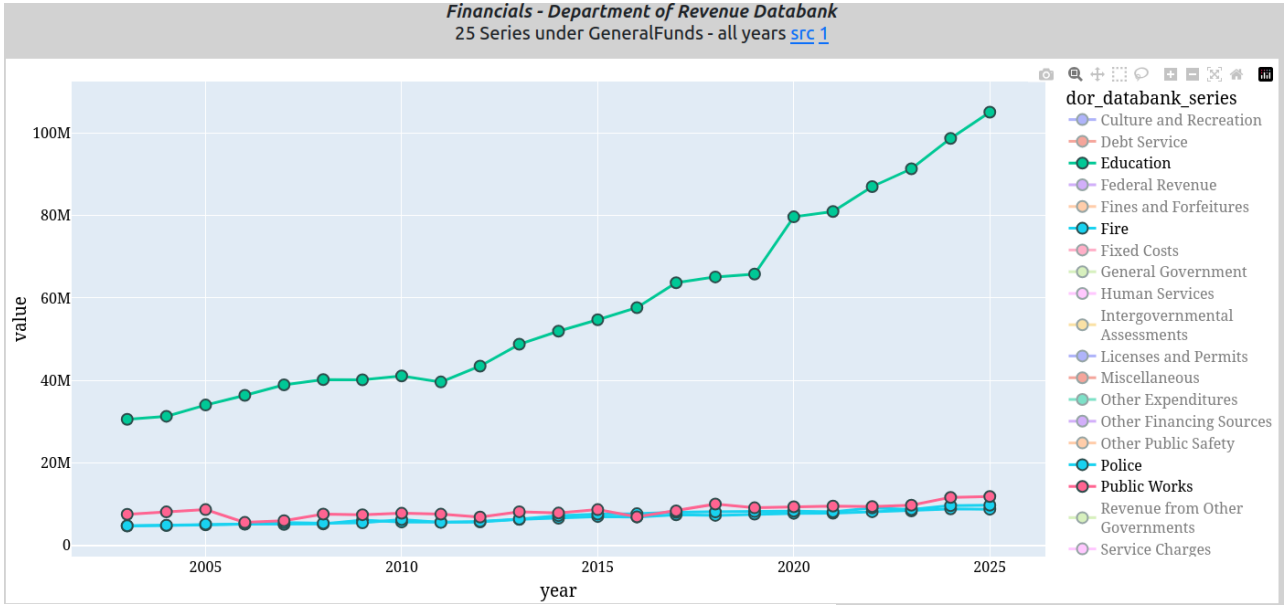
"Politics is the art of the possible" - Otto von Bismark

Over the past six weeks, we explored some truths about the structural financial defects in the Arlington Public Schools, listed, summarized and linked below. Follow the links for detail of each section.

tl;dr APS spending is unsustainable with no justification amid decreased enrollments resulting in repeated, unnecessary, humongous overrides making Arlington unaffordable.

1/16/26 School Enrollment 1.41% Average Annual Increase, School Spending 5.78% Average Annual Increase

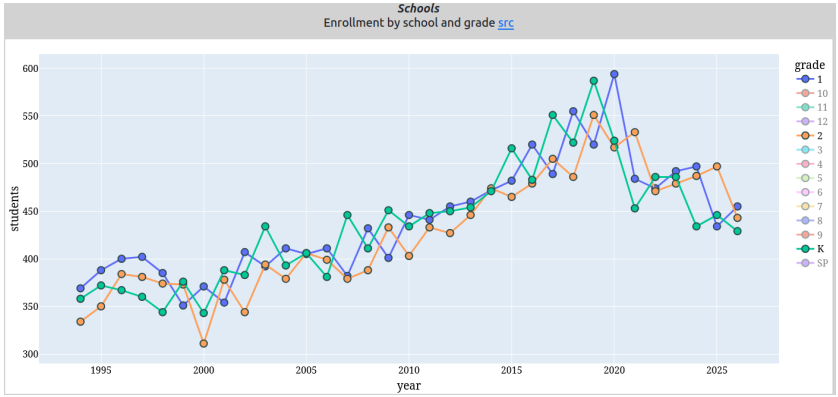
Police, Fire, DPW all stay within budget. Education is the budget buster.



Year	Expense	Department	YoY	Annualized
2025	$2,868,456	Culture and Recreation	6.54%	0.73%
2025	$4,077,654	Intergovernmental Assessments	3.00%	1.62%
2025	$11,813,138	Public Works	1.79%	2.08%
2025	$29,119,855	State Revenue	2.90%	**2.43%**
2025	$8,733,620	Fire	-0.87%	2.89%
2025	$9,719,188	Police	1.09%	3.34%
2025	$8,698,445	General Government	3.74%	3.51%
2025	$224,209,281	Total Revenues	4.27%	4.38%
2025	$214,261,644	Total Expenditures	2.56%	4.54%
2025	$173,783,072	Taxes	7.61%	4.57%
2025	$41,475,674	Fixed Costs	5.49%	4.72%
2025	$1,605,229	Human Services	3.71%	4.92%
2025	$19,929,471	Debt Service	-16.04%	5.19%
2025	$105,101,294	Education	6.44%	**5.78%**
2025	$11,358,859	Transfers	2.29%	8.70%
2025	$4,952,608	Licenses and Permits	-1.79%	9.74%
2025	$4,111,604	Miscellaneous	9.34%	11.02%

1/21/26 APS Enrollment Decline K-2

APS Enrollment has peaked, declining in K-2 last 5 years and over the foreseeable future.



Kindergarten trend in enrollments next four years:

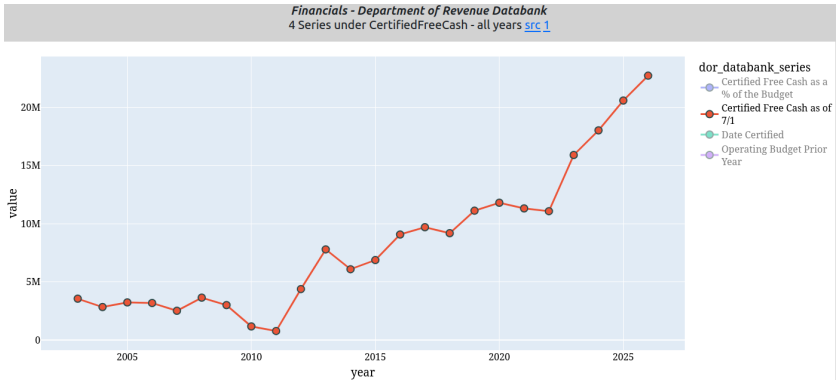
children born between:
254 9/1/2020 - 8/31/2021 ages 4.5 - 5.5
281 9/1/2021 - 8/31/2022 ages 3.5 - 4.5
269 9/2/2022 - 8/31/2023 ages 2.5 - 3.5
292 9/2/2023 - 8/31/2024 ages 1.5 - 2.5

Current K enrollment 429

Pre-school enrollments decreased from 100 to 79 in 2026, a 21% decline.

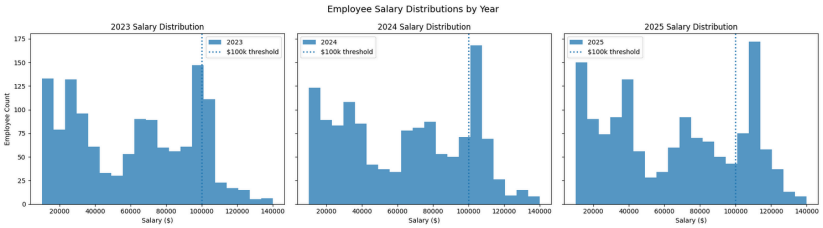
2/4/26 Underestimating Revenues and Overestimating Expenses to Support an Unnecessary Override

Free cash balance explodes! 10% of budget, $22M+ balance.



2/11/26 Recent 8% Compounded Salary Expense in Arlington Public Schools is Unsustainable

Expenses dominated (85%) by an expanding payroll with a 7% CAGR, but we have no control over expenses because of inflation?



2/15/26 History of Overrides

Arlington's $14.8M override will be the largest in MA history. Arlington will have 5 of the top 25 overrides in MA history!

DOR Code	Municipality	Fiscal Year	Vote Date	Win / Loss	Yes Votes	No Votes	Vote Type	Department	Description	Amount ▾
178	Melrose	2026	11/4/2025	WIN	6,018	5,052	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Override	13,500,000
046	Brookline	2024	5/2/2023	WIN	7,516	4,799	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Question 2a Operating Override	11,983,367
207	Newton	2003	4/30/2002	WIN	14,251	13,542	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	General Government And School Expenditures	11,500,000
344	Winchester	2020	3/26/2019	WIN	2,849	1,901	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Operating Budget And Building Stab Fund	10,000,000
271	Shrewsbury	2022	5/4/2021	WIN	4,344	2,781	Override	SCHOOL	Muni And School Operating Budget	9,500,000
284	Stoneham	2027	12/9/2025	WIN	4,001	3,274	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Funding School And Town Expenses For Fy27	9,300,000
189	Milton	2026	4/29/2025	WIN	5,564	3,227	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Purposes Of Funding Municipal Government Operational Override Of The Town And Schools ($8,800,000)	8,800,000
026	Belmont	2025	4/2/2024	WIN	5,151	4,060	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Supplement Cap Budget & Town, School Oper Budgets	8,400,000
207	Newton	2014	3/12/2013	WIN	9,653	8,203	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Funding Municipal And School Operating	8,400,000
040	Braintree	2025	6/26/2024	WIN	5,493	2,764	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Purposes Of Funding The Following Departmental Expenses: General Municipal Government ($2,500,000), School Department ($4,000,000 And To Fund An Override Stabilization Fund For Gener Municipal And School Department Operations (1,500,000) For The Fiscal Yea	8,000,000
131	Hingham	2024	4/24/2023	WIN	3,515	2,123	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Override	7,890,467
046	Brookline	2016	5/5/2015	WIN	6,325	3,958	Override	SCHOOL	Fund Additional Enrollment In Brookline Public Schools And Expenditures In Municipal Departments	7,665,000
100	Framingham	2003	6/11/2002	WIN	6,877	6,536	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Funding General Operating Expenses	7,173,239
010	Arlington	2025	11/7/2023	WIN	7,951	4,964	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Operating Override	7,000,000
198	Natick	2026	3/25/2025	WIN	4,659	3,040	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Operational Override	7,000,000
002	Acton	2025	4/30/2024	WIN	3,191	3,154	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Public Schools And Muni Government	6,600,000
046	Brookline	2019	5/8/2018	WIN	5,412	2,371	Override	SCHOOL	Funding The Cost Of Expenditures In The Public Schools	6,575,425
197	Nantucket	2024	5/23/2023	WIN	1,096	994	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Affordable Housing Override	6,500,000
211	North Attleborough	2019	4/3/2018	WIN	4,330	3,216	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Funding	6,500,000
010	Arlington	2012	6/7/2011	WIN	7,226	6,366	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Funding Operating Budgets Of Town And School	6,490,000
046	Brookline	2009	5/6/2008	WIN	5,236	4,305	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Funding School, Police, Fire, And Library Depts. Etc	6,200,000
010	Arlington	2006	6/11/2005	WIN	7,126	6,570	Override	SCHOOL	Fund Town And School Budgets	6,000,000
105	Georgetown	2026	5/12/2025	WIN	1,659	1,348	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Override	6,000,000
220	Norwood	2020	6/3/2019	WIN	5,629	1,821	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	For Municipal Government, School Department Operations And Establishing A Stabilization Fund For Both	5,950,000
010	Arlington	2020	6/11/2019	WIN	8,655	4,029	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Town And School Operating Budget	5,500,000
271	Shrewsbury	2015	6/3/2014	WIN	7,102	2,704	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Funding Municipal And School Operating And Capital Expenses	5,500,000
244	Randolph	2009	4/1/2008	WIN	3,578	2,901	Override	SCHOOL	Operating Randolph Public Schools	5,480,738
178	Melrose	2020	4/2/2019	WIN	6,084	4,875	Override	SCHOOL	General Operation Of School	5,180,000
197	Nantucket	2022	6/15/2021	WIN	1,147	432	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	Purpose Of Supporting The Operation Of Our Island Home	5,000,000
164	Lynnfield	2026	6/4/2025	WIN	1,897	1,042	Override	GENERAL OPERATING	Fy26 Budget	4,650,000
348	Worcester	1992	6/1/1991	WIN	17,997	16,380	Override	SCHOOL	Funding School Department Positions	4,583,000
344	Winchester	2003	4/16/2002	WIN	4,465	3,390	Override	GENERAL GOVERNMENT	General Operating Budget	4,550,000
026	Belmont	2016	4/7/2015	WIN	4,733	3,837	Override	SCHOOL	Supplementing The Capital Budget Of The Town And School Operating Budgets	4,500,000

2/24/26 Budget Fudge It

APS budget presentations are misleading with key metrics subject to revision and inconsistent with DESE standards.

Arlington Public Schools
Education That Empowers

Arlington Public Schools Budget Facts and Figures

$103,630,672	FY26 school district operating budget (general fund)
$19,788,143	Chapter 70 State Aid (FY26 Preliminary – Governor's Budget)
$83,466	Average teacher salary / state average $86,118 (DESE) (FY22)
$19,471	Per pupil cost (all funds) / state average $21,885 (DESE) (FY23)
6,113	Students enrolled as of 10/1/25 (DESE)
1061.0	School district general fund employees budgeted (FY26 FTE - full-time equivalents)
668	Teachers budgeted in FY26 (FTE - full-time equivalents)
97.1%	Arlington High School 2023 4-year cohort graduation rate (state rate is 89.2%)
34	Athletic programs offered at high school level in 2024-25, with 65 total teams
12.2 to 1	Student teacher ratio 2023-2024 / state ratio 11.8 to 1 (DESE)
11	# of public schools in Arlington, including Menotomy Preschool

2/25/26 Fee Revenues from AASP and Community Education

APS stonewalls simple public records request. Where did $4M go?

342 - APS Childcare	3999 - Systemwide Expense	DAY CARE PROVIDER	7.00	7.00	0.00	7.00	0.00
		MANAGER OF DAY CARE	1.00	1.00	0.00	1.00	0.00
			8.00	8.00	0.00	8.00	0.00
343 - Community Education	3801 - Comm Ed - Adult Education	ADMINISTRATIVE ASSISTANT	1.00	1.00	0.00	1.00	0.00
		ADULT PROGRAM COORDINATOR	1.00	1.00	0.00	1.00	0.00
		DIRECTOR OF COMMUNITY EDUCATION	1.00	1.00	0.00	1.00	0.00
		PROGRAM OPERATIONS COORDINATOR	1.00	1.00	0.00	1.00	0.00
	3809 - Comm Ed - Kidzone	ADULT PROGRAM COORDINATOR	1.00	1.00	0.00	1.00	0.00
		MARKETING & PROMOTIONS COORDINATOR	0.69	0.69	0.00	0.69	0.00
		YOUTH & TEEN PROGRAM COORDINATOR	2.00	2.00	0.00	2.00	0.00
			7.69	7.69	0.00	7.69	0.00
341 - AASP	3902 - Extended Day	AASP TEACHER	1.00	1.00	0.00	1.00	0.00
		DIRECTOR OF AFTER SCHOOL PROGRAM	1.00	1.00	0.00	1.00	0.00
		SITE COORDINATOR	4.00	4.00	0.00	4.00	0.00

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				YES on Override Scenario		NO on Override Scenario	
Department	***Program***	***Position***	**FY26 FTE (Actual)**	**FY27 FTE:**	**Var:**	**FY27 FTE:**	**Var:**
			6.00	6.00	0.00	6.00	0.00

3/10/26 Trust, easily lost, never recovered

The APS maintains at least 3 sets of ledgers with minimal oversight co-mingling the funds

- $136M+ Town Meeting appropriation
- $26M+ Chapter 70/grant revenues
- $4M+ unreported revolving funds (AASP and Community Education)

Jeffrey Skilling would be proud!

Funding Summary Chart - NO ON OVERRIDE SCENARIO

B No on Override Scenario

Funding Description	FY22	FY23	FY24	FY25	FY26	FY27 Projected	Variance	%
General Fund	**$80,104,634**	**$88,947,334**	**$89,347,334**	**$96,521,248**	**$103,630,672**	**$103,630,672**	**$0**	**0.00%**
Town Revenue and Property Taxes	$65,363,526	$70,243,925	$70,643,925	$77,191,655	$83,383,979	$82,924,754	-$459,225	-0.55%
Chapter 70 State Aid	$14,741,108	$18,703,409	$18,703,409	$19,329,593	$20,246,693	$20,705,918	$459,225	2.27%

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"Politics is the art of whatever you can get away with" - Arlington officials